

THE NEW PRIME MINISTER

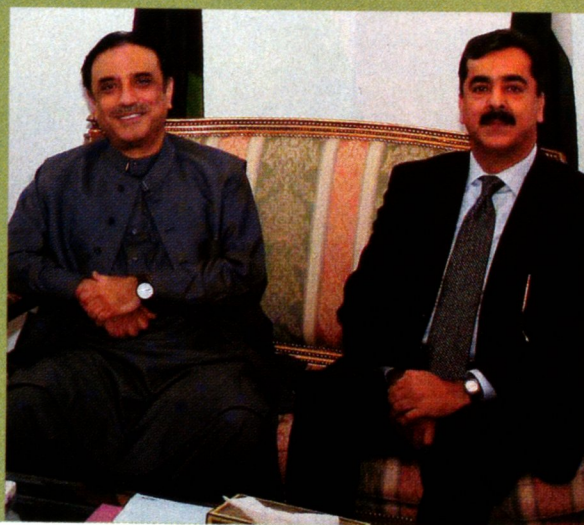
Man for the Moment

Pakistan's new chief executive, Makhdoom Syed Yusuf Raza Gilani, has the aristocratic look of a man born to expect reverence. Even his name, suffixed with the spiritually deferential 'Makhdoom' and 'Syed' commands respect in his hometown of Multan where he is heir to a spiritual and political dynasty that is the custodian of an ancestral Sufi shrine. His great-grandfather, Makhdoom Ranjhan Bakhsh Gilani served as member of the Central Legislative Assembly of India from 1921 to 1936 and his father Makhdoom Alamdar Hussain Gilani, and various uncles and cousins were elected legislators. Local influence has always translated into political ambition in his family. Yet, what may sometimes be perceived as an aloof demeanour also masks the new premier's shyness, born

WARMING THE SEAT:
Gilani (right) with Zardari

out of his status as a local boy-made-good from a marginalised area.

Born in 1952, the polite and soft-spoken Gilani has become Pakistan's first elected prime minister from what is called the Seraiki belt, in southern Punjab. He is generally seen as a "decent" and principled man and his loyalty to PPP is widely admired. Jailed for almost six years under Musharraf for misusing his authority



to induct unqualified people from his area into government, he did not switch allegiance despite severe pressure. His political career began with PML but he fell out with it and joined PPP. He defeated the then Punjab chief minister Nawaz Sharif from Multan in the 1988 elections and was made the Railways' minister.

Observers say that his Punjabi roots were a major factor for his elevation. PPP would like to rebuild itself in Pakistan's largest province and it is also suspected that PPP Co-Chairman Asif Zardari did not want a Sindhi such as Makhdoom Amin Fahim to establish an alternate centre of power. Gilani's vaunted loyalty may also be useful if Zardari has a change of heart. Although Zardari has stressed that Gilani will be PPP's premier for the next five years, many continue to believe that Benazir's widower nurtures ambitions of becoming prime minister himself and may, at some point, ask his nominee to step aside. If such a thing comes to pass, the best Gilani could hope for is for such a transition to be honourable.

is in danger of fizzling out. Inflation is at its highest over the past 10 years with food prices, in particular, growing at the rate of 14 per cent in February. With rising fuel prices and a devaluing Pakistan rupee, this figure is expected to rise even further and could spark public protests. Also, massive power cuts in Karachi are affecting businesses in the commercial capital and adding to the fears of an economic recession. "Much of the visible affluence of the past years, it seems, was primarily due to post-9/11 factors rather than any good management of the economy," says political economist Akbar Zaidi. "The government went in for short-term schemes with quick returns rather than substantially improving the economy and this is coming back to haunt them. The economy is not collapsing but it's certainly going down."

Another equally significant challenge facing the new premier is the

issue of security. With rising incidences of suicide bombings, fears about Pakistan's internal security have multiplied both domestically and internationally. While most see the attacks as a fallout of army action in the tribal areas bordering Afghanistan—and, by extension, an "indiscriminate" American war against terrorism—Washington is concerned about Pakistan staying the course in its attempt to root out militancy.

Well-placed sources indicate that the most recent attacks—including the car bomb attacks on the offices of an anti-terrorism body in Lahore—have the hallmark of direct Al Qaeda involvement rather than of home-grown militants. Intelligence estimates also contend that roughly 50 foreign militants—Arabs, Uzbeks and Chechens—are entering Pakistan every day, fleeing from US operations in Afghanistan.

Pakistan, the sources contend, is caught between the conflicting policy imperatives of three of its closest allies. While one ally, the US, wants Pakistan to go hard after the militants, Saudi Arabia and the UAE want militants to be contained within Pakistan and not forced to look for possible refuge in their lands.

PPP may be more beholden to the US than Sharif—after all it was the US-brokered deal that allowed Bhutto to return from self-exile and led to the dropping of charges against her. But Gilani will also have to tackle populist sentiment against his party's pragmatism vis-a-vis the US. How these issues are handled will determine how far Gilani can take a coalition that has the potential of fracturing along ideological lines.

Gilani may be basking in the glow of a new spring in Islamabad. But given the challenges in front of him, few would envy his position. ■